Murder in Harrowdale

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Murder in Harrowdale is designed for 4-6 level 1-2 PCs of non-evil alignment. It takes place in the Forgotten Realms, in the small village New Velar in Harrowdale, which is a part of the Dalelands. The module can be run using any setting where you'd find a small village and woodlands nearby. All encounters can easily be modified to fit either a larger or a smaller party.

A travelling merchant is found brutally murdered in a local inn. The innkeeper, which is a member of the local council, asks the PCs to solve the crime. Their investigation takes the PCs to a nearby forest. Will they make it out alive?

This book is meant for the Dungeon Master and refers the Player's Handbook, Dungeon Master's Guide, Monster Manual and Volo's Guide to Monsters. Spells and items are described in the Player's Handbook, magic items can be found in Dungeon Master's Guide and stat blocks for monsters and villains are in the Monster Manual and Volo's Guide to Monsters.

Adventure background

Few tendays ago Olaf Andoin, a get-rich-quick merchant from Mulmaster, captured two pixies, Glowie and Storm. He simply couldn't believe his luck but didn't know what to do or how he could turn this fortune of his into hard currency. After a while, he noticed that pixie dust seemed to settle in the bottom of the pixie cages. He gathered the dust and mixed it with some lavender oil, which he had in stock, and decided to sell it as a remedy for whatever he believed ailed whomever showed interest in his wares.

A couple of days ago Olaf came to New Velar, a small town on the shores of the Sea of Fallen Stars and part of the Dalelands. He managed to earn a few silver pieces by selling Pixie dust oil, the perfect remedy to your aching joints. He also earned the attention of Brurum the redcap, an evil murderous fey creature and a lacky for Hladgerdur, a green hag that lived in a Velarswoods, not far away. Hladgerdur and Brurum had been capturing sprites and other small fey creatures in the forest, which they tortured, boiled and even ate.

Brurum, invisible after drinking potion of invisibility, decided to follow Olaf back to the Seven Burghars' rest, where he was staying. After finding out in which room the merchant was staying he entered the room and murdered Olaf and took the two pixies, to bring them to Hladgerdur.

Adventure overview

Kolmar Greycloak, the innkeeper in the Seven Burghars' Rest and a member of New Velar's ruling council, asks the PCs to find whoever murdered Olaf, once the merchant's mutilated body is discovered. After discovering few leads in the merchant's room the PCs follow a trail into the Velarswood.

After finding their way trough the woods the PCs finally find the hag's lair, which is cleverly hidden. The lair itself is guarded by blink dogs and a few traps, making it hard for the PCs to find Hladgerdur and Brurum in their lair.

If the PCs manage to defeat the evil pair they can return victorious to New Velar.

In New Velar and Velarswoods

New Velar, formerly known as Harrowdale town, is not a large village. About 200 people live in the town proper but around 500 people live in Harrowdale. There the PCs can find a blacksmith, a general store (see PHB), skinner and a temple devoted to Chauntea. There are also shrines devoted to Mielikki, Eldath and Umberlee. New Velar is both an agricultural center and a fishing village, since it has a decent natural harbor. Feel free to add whatever locations you feel are necessary for your group.

The only inn, Seven Burghars' Rest (a two story wooden house), is run by Kolmar Greycloak, who is a member of the ruling council of the town, and his daughter, Verlinda. The inn is cozy, only on one floor (the family lives on the second floor) and every night the locals gather there to sing, dance and gossip. Whether the PCs are newcomers or locals is up to you, but the text presumes that the PCs are new in town. Read or paraphrase the following:

The Seven Burghars' rest is a cosy inn, where laughter, song and the smell of roasted poultry greets you the moment you open the wooden door. A large fireplace stands in one corner, a carved bar table in the other and long benches by the walls. The chandelier is made from deer antlers and it's easy to imagine by the look of it, that it is much older than the establishment. A woman in her early thirties walks over to you, her smile warm as her flaming red hair. She wears a brooch in her collar, one depicting blooming rose and rich wheat. 'Well met, travelers, and welcome to the Seven Burghars' rest. My name is Verlinda and my father runs this humble inn. You sure have the look of adventurers about you. We don't see many of you here. Feel free to sit where you please and I'll be with you shortly.'

With a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs recognize the symbol as the holy symbol of Chauntea.

There are few tables in the common room but there are available seats on the benches along the walls. After a short while Verlinda returns with mugs of ale. She asks the PCs about their travels and their adventures, laughs and seems to be enjoying their company if they treat her well. After a while Tomas, a local bard, starts playing in his lute and the local crowd starts singing and dancing.

If the PCs look around they might notice a thin black haired human. His eyes are dark but his smile charming. This is Olaf Andoin, a merchant from Mulmaster, who recently arrived in New Velar to sell his Pixie Dust Oil, the perfect cure for you aching

joints or what you need to make him or her fall in love with you, or whatever Olaf believes you need to hear in order to make the sale. Olaf is the kind of person that would steal his grandmother's liver and sell it to her again, if he suspected that he could make a silver coin on it.

The Pixie Dust Oil is simply lavender oil mixed with pixie dust and has absolutely no magical properties. Olaf mixes the oil using the dust that falls to the bottom of the cages where he keeps his captured pixies, Glowie and Storm. This is something that Olaf will not share with anyone. If the PCs chat with Olaf he is charming and friendly. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs get the feeling that there's something more to the merchant's oils than he is willing to share.

As the night wears on the crowd grows larger and the Seven Burghars' seems a very fun place indeed. Olaf goes to be early and, if the PCs talked with him, he thanks them for keeping him company in "this rather dull town." With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**, the PCs get the feeling that Olaf must be rather heavy, as his footsteps are not light. This however is Brurum, the redcap, following Olaf hidden by invisibility spell. The fey makes sure that his feet fall down at the same time as Olaf's, in hope that no one will notice him.

The murder

When night has fallen a shrill scream echoes from outside. A young girl sees where Brurum leaves through Olaf's window, his cap drenched in blood, and runs towards Velarswoods, not far away. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs hear her scream. Read or paraphrase the following if the PCs decide to investigate. If the PCs either fail their check or decide to ignore it, they see where other guests stand up and rush outside.

> You, along with a few other patrons, rush outside to find a teenage girl outside. Her face is pale, as if the blood has been drained from it and tears fill her eyes.

The girl's name is Tasha. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel that the girl is shaken and saw something that frightened her. With a successful **DC 12 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the PCs manage to calm Tasha down. She is able to tell the people there that she saw a small horrible old man climb from that window (she points to one of the windows of the Seven Burghar's Rest), blood pouring from the cap on his head. He held a bag and she swears by Chauntea that something moved inside the bag. The old man had a sickle and wore heavy steel boots.

If the PCs decide to investigate, they find the window to Olaf's room open. Olaf's body is horrible mutilated on the bed, it has large slashing marks and there's blood everywhere. With a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs see that someone has ransacked the room after Olaf was killed, since there are many bloody footsteps, all the clothes have been taken from the closet and Olaf's bags emptied on the floor. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Medicine) check** the PCs notice that one of the wounds seems different than the others, as if something has been pushed into the wound. Brurum did this to drench his cap in Olaf's blood. With a successful **DC 5 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs notice that there are two broken bird cages in pieces by the bed and the floor seems to sparkle around them. With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs know that the sparkling is due to Pixie dust. The two pixies, Glowie and Storm, were held captive by Olaf in the cages, but Brurum caught them and put them in his bag.

Outside the window is an obvious trail left by the heavy and bloody boots that Brurum wears. It leads into Velarswoods. With a successful **DC 5 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs can follow the trail to the outskirts of the forest. With a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs know that Velarswoods can be dangerous, since it is home to cloakers, stirges, trolls and other creatures. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Survival) checks** the PCs manage to follow Brurum's trail into the clearing, where Hladgerdur has her lair. If the PCs fail any other their checks, following the trail, feel free to add encounters you feel appropriate.

The clearing

Hladgerdur has cunningly hidden her lair in basalt rock formations by a small pond. Brurum´s trail leads to the clearing but disappears by the rocks. The pond is dark and deep, devoid of all life save for buzzing insects and a few frogs. Read or paraphrase the following:

> You enter a large clearing. Large basalt stacks jut from the ground by a dark pond, in stark contrast with the green and lush forest. The rocks reach over ten feet up into the air. The air is damp and

insects buzz all around you, while frogs chirp by the small pond. As you get closer you notice the putrid smell that comes from the pond.

If the PCs decide to investigate the pond they might discover that Hladgerdur has found her use for it. With a successful **DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to dive to the bottom of the pond. There's a drain in the pond, that leads into room 1 and is linked with the trap in it. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs spot the mechanics. If the PCs wish to disable the trap they need to dive down and use thieves' tools. With a successful **DC 12 Dexterity check,** using thieves' tools, the PCs manage to disable the trap. Since they are doing this underwater they have disadvantage to the roll.

If the PCs decide to investigate the rocks they might spot the secret door leading to Hladgerdur's lair. With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs spot a place where a dark entrance has been hidden in a shadow-clad crevasse. A dwarf PC has advantage to the roll due to dwarves' affinity with rocks and stones. Read or paraphrase the following:

You see a cleverly hidden doorway in a dark crevasse, hiding steps that lead down into darkness.

The stairs lead down to room 1. The doorway is narrow, only allowing one person to enter at a time.

The Lair of Hladgerdur

The hag's lair used to be the home of a dwarf sorcerer, Gunnar Trollhammer, that was cast out of his clan for studying dark magic. Gunnar, who slowly grew insane, was slain decades ago and his small lair fell into disuse. Hladgerdur discovered the lair only few months ago and claimed it as her own. She has done a few changes to the lair, so it is more to her liking.

Lights and visibility

The ceiling seems to glow with eerie purple light. Hladgerdur installed phosphorene fungi, that give of this eerie light.

Walls

All walls are made of stone, worked and even, unless otherwise noted. There are faded runes etched into many stones, containing dwarven litanies aimed at the Trollhammer clan. A dwarven PC might recognize many of these.

Doors

All doors are made of fey hardwood, that Hladgerdur installed. They seem to quiver with life and are impossible hard. With a successful **DC 20 Strength check** the PCs manage to break down the doors. Doors are unlocked unless otherwise noted.

1: Gold and water

The first room of Hladgerdur's lair is trapped. Hladgerdur created a nasty trap, intended to trap and drown those who enter her lair in hope of ransacking it.

The steps lead down to an open red door, that reveals a large room. The walls are of even, dark stone but the air is humid. A strange green line is on all walls by the ceiling. In the middle of the room stands a small open chest, from where you stand you can see something glitter inside it. Across the room is another door, made of the same red wood. The room has the same putrid smell as the dark pond in the clearing.

The chest is trapped. With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs notice that the chest stands on a very sensitive trigger plate. The chest is filled with silver pieces, removing more than two pieces from the chest triggers the trap. If the trap is triggered the doors slam shut and lock, as water starts to pour into the room. With a successful **DC 18**

Dexterity check using thieves' tools the PCs manage to disable the pressure plate. The chest contains 55 silver pieces and 64 copper pieces. If the PCs trigger the trap, read or paraphrase the following:

> The doors slam shut, and you hear an audible click. With a shudder you suddenly hear rushing water. Before you can react, water starts pouring into the room through three holes high in the walls.

With a successful **DC 13 Dexterity check** using thieves tools the PCs manage to unlock the doors. Doing so disables the trap and the water stops flowing into the room. If the PCs decide to investigate the walls, they might find the holes where the water comes from. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs see the holes.

The door leading to room 2 is unlocked if the trap hasn't been triggered.

2: Dogs and Crystals

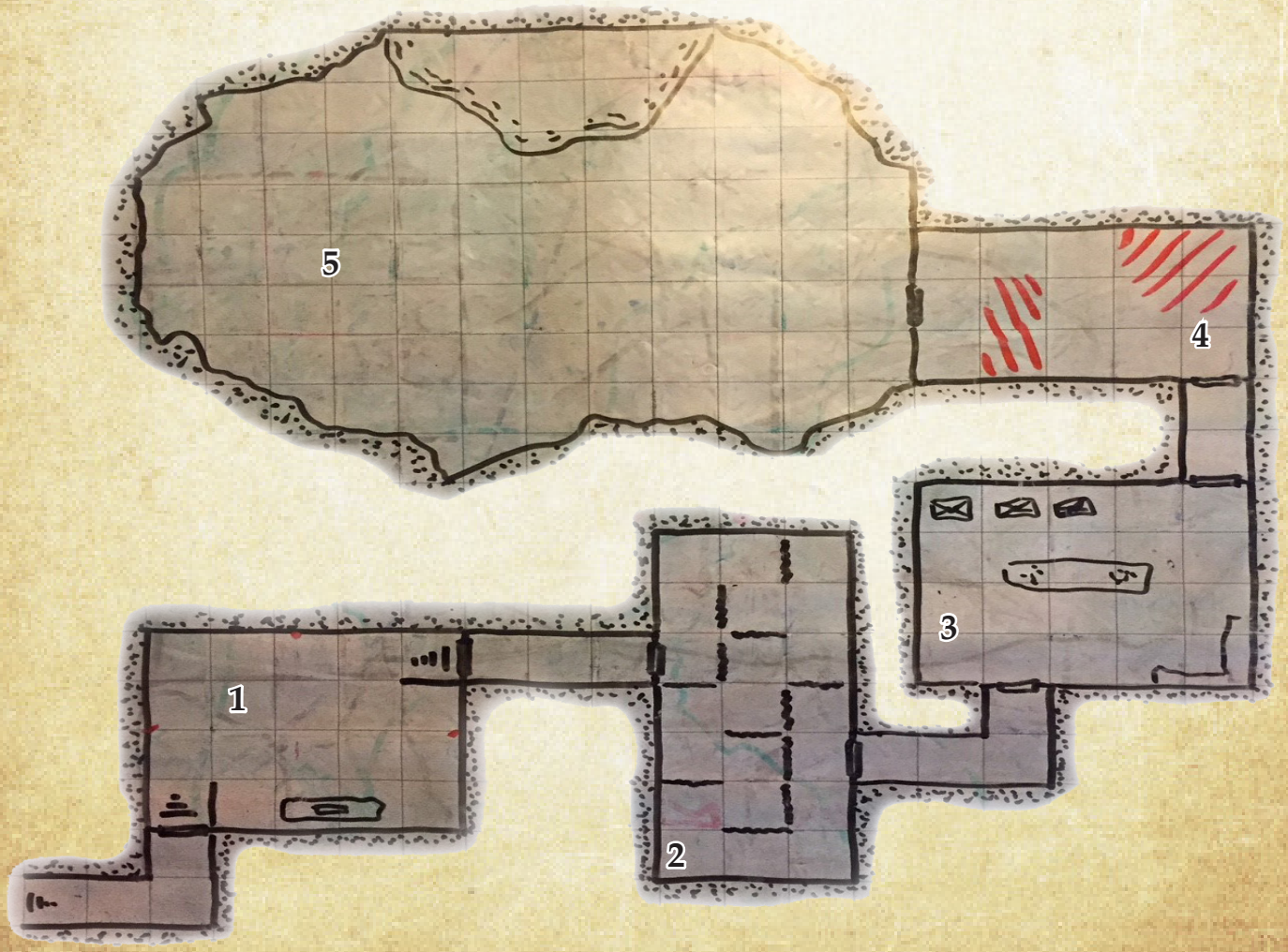
Hladgerdur has trained four blink dogs (see MM) to guard her lair. She feeds them with the bodies of pixies, sprites and other fey creatures that she and Brurum manage to capture and have used in their experiments. The dogs are trained to attack anyone save for Hladgerdur and Brurum.

> As you enter through the doorway you hear a sharp bark. You look around and see that the room is lined with thick, clear, crystalline walls, that are laid across the room, making it almost maze-like. The bark seemed to have come from one of the four sleek, sharp teethed canines that stare at you and growl.

What makes this room special is the fact that it is almost a maze, made with crystalline see-through walls. This makes it almost impossible for any intruder to use ranged weapons or spells. The blink dogs are quite cunning and try to teleport behind the weakest looking intruder, using hit and run tactics.

3: Pixies and Potions

Hladgerdur's alchemy lab is a horrible place. She conducts her alchemy experiments here, where she, with the help of Brurum, tries to create potions by extracting the essence of fey creatures, using whatever torture necessary.



A foul rotting stench assaults you as you enter the room, bringing water to your eyes. In the middle of it is a table, that a tiny blue skinned creature has been strapped to. Its chest is open and some of its organs lie scattered on the table beside it. Some sort of alchemy lab is in one corner where something is being concocted. Tubes and bottles are interlinked, allowing steam and moisture to pass from one bottle to the next, and it all ends in a small vial, that is slowly being filled with blue liquid. In the other corner you can see three cages, where two tiny winged creatures eye you wearily.

If the PCs investigate the alchemy lab they discover that a small heart at one end and is being slowly cooked, that ends as the blue liquid. Investigating the corpse of the tiny blue creature they can discover that its heart is gone. With a successful **DC 5 Intelligence (Medicine) check** the PCs see this. The liquid in the vial is a Potion of Speed. With a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs know the smell of the potion and identify it. The dead creature on the table was a quickling (see Volo's p. 187). With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs recognize the body.

If the PCs set the Pixies free they can warn the PCs about the hag. They also know a thing or two about Brurum. The pixies' names are Glowie and Storm. Glowie is fair haired and soft spoken, Storm is hot headed and distrusts anyone larger than him, after his experience with Olaf and Brurum. With a successful **DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the PCs manage to convince the pixies to speak with them.

What the Pixies know

Glowie and Storm can tell the PCs of how Olaf captured them and used their dust to create the Pixie Dust Oil. They also know that Brurum killed Olaf and Storm recognized Brurum as redcap. Glowie has heard about Hladgerdur and though the pair hasn't met her yet, she knows that Hladgerdur is an evil green hag, that delights in torturing other fey creatures, especially those who are smaller than her.

4: Pits and Poison

This used to be where Gunnar trained and perfected his Art. There are old scorch marks on the walls and many tiles are broken.

Hladgerdur has installed two traps in this room, to make sure that any intruder that makes it this far enters her lair at least wounded.

The first trap is a 30 feet deep spiked pit (see DMG p. 120). The pit is covered with weak tiles that break easily. The second trap is a magical one, if triggered it fills the with a Stinking Cloud (see PHB p. 278). With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs notice that the runes in the walls are different by the trap.

If either trap is triggered, Hladgerdur and Brurum are ready for any intruders.

5: The hag and her lackey

Hladgerdur's lair is the only room where the walls are rough and uneven. Gunnar Trollhammer never got the chance to finish this room before he was killed. In one end of the room is a small pond, where there's a secret entrance to a lake in the Underdark.

Once the PCs enter the lair they find Brurum (see Volo's p. 188) and Hladgerdur (see MM p. 176). If the PCs do not trigger the traps in room 4 they find Hladgerdur and Brurum surprised. If the pair is ready for the PCs Hladgerdur changes her appearance so that she seems to be a fair elven maiden, one in distress and very afraid of Brurum. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs get the feeling that there's something off about the maiden. If the PCs fall for the rouse Brurum and Hladgerdur attack the PCs in full force as they approach.

If the PCs either surprise the PCs or see through Hladgerdur's act, Hladgerdur turns invisible, while Brurum charges the largest PC and fights to the death. Hladgerdur will use hit and fade tactics, while Brurum is alive. If Brurum dies or if Hladgerdur goes below 50% hp, she turns invisible and tries to flee using the secret tunnel in the pond.

Conclusion

If the PCs manage to defeat Brurum and Hladgerdur they should've earned enough intelligence to solve the murder case. If they return to Harrowdale and tell Kolmar about what they found, he is grateful and convinces the town council to pay the group 50 gps each for their heroic acts.